

NC and Thereafter Remembered

Bill Worstell

5/23/2026

This summer is the 50th Reunion for my Class Reunion of North Central High School in Spokane, and I am looking forward to it. Looking over my yearbook, I remember my teachers and my friends as they were at that time fondly. North Central prepared me well academically and socially for Harvard College and then Harvard University in Boston where I live now. I did my best in Boston to represent my hometown to many interesting and accomplished friends whom I'd like to introduce to my friends back home; I am proud of what they have done for us all. I also proudly brought high school tales from my hometown to Harvard, and I am happy to report that we shone with the best of 'em there; part of me never left Spokane. My journey was like making it to the State Tournament sent by our team of teams at NC; I did my best, and I'd like to share some of what I learned.

I also wanted to pay tribute to the North Central High School community and Class of 1976, the Bicentennial Class, just two years after Expo '74, teachers and students (and staff). First, I will present some personal memories of NC and my friends there, then I would like to share some autobiographical anecdotes from my own unusual perspective, especially on what I've learned about perspectives and projections, and about teams, from work in High-Energy Particle Physics and in Molecular and X-ray Tomographic Imaging. I've helped as a member of teams that designed and built body scanners, some of which were used at the Massachusetts General Hospital for research work there. I have studied many ways to form digital twins which will be the cartoon versions of ourselves which will accompany us on our future hospital visits; AI has reshaped our field, and has hinted at what is to come.

At North Central in our youth we learned both how to be the best version of ourselves we could be as individuals and as members of teams, part of a team of teams, part of a community, part of a city, state, country, world, and universe of which we were just as much a member as anyone or anything else. We belong, we are needed, and we have friends and helpers.

Life Lesson Learned: We carry a part of every person we meet within ourselves forever, especially family, friends, and teachers; remembering old friends and benefactors reminds us of the wonderful tapestry of life that we all enjoy, join to form and establish, and contribute to and live by.

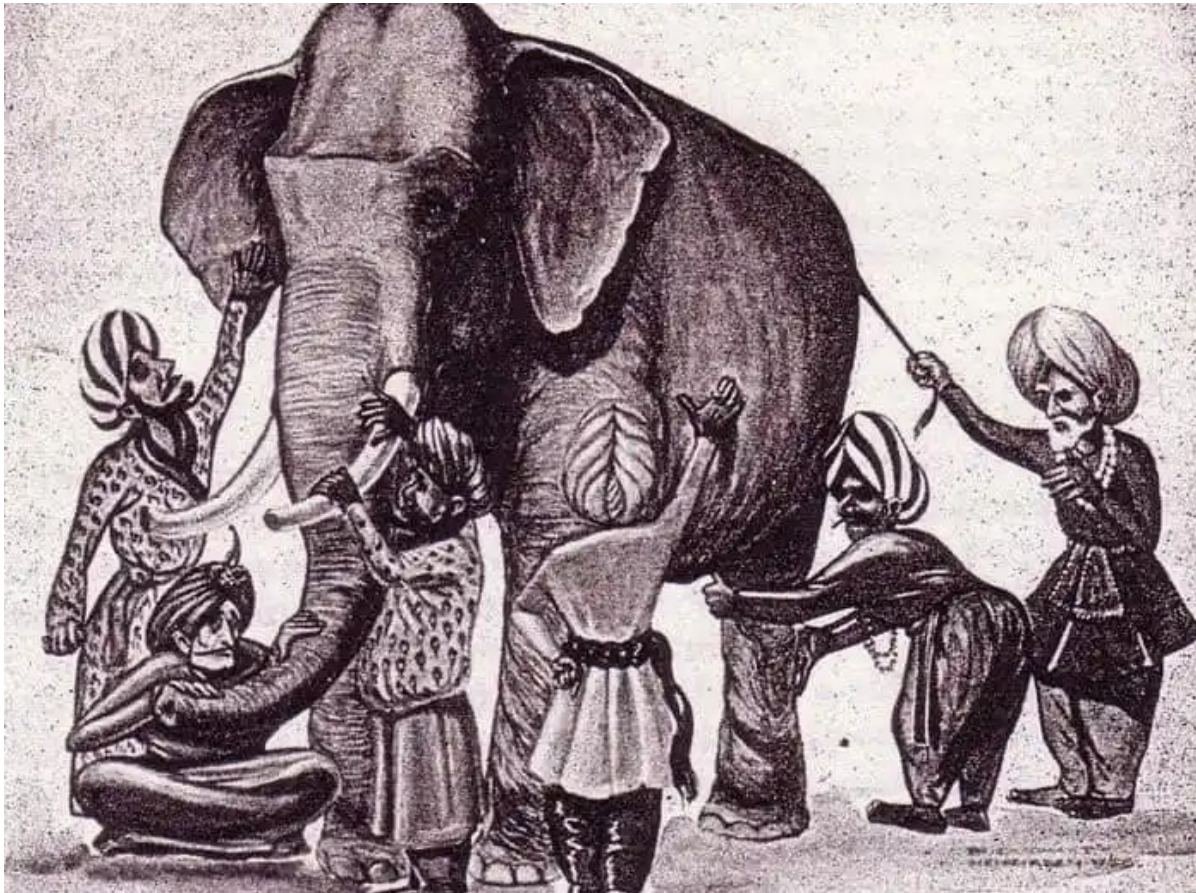
Examining our group from the perspectives of each singly and all collectively enriches our understanding. It helps us to grasp our complexity, essence, and wonder; it gives us hope for what we can do together.

[https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/North_Central_High_School_\(Spokane,_Washington\)](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/North_Central_High_School_(Spokane,_Washington))



The Many-Sidedness of Reality

The overarching metaphor which I have applied is the Buddha's parable of the blind men and the elephant. Now combine that with Applied Mathematics, also known as Computer Science or more recently Data Science (AI for short, being Artificial in having been built by us, and Intelligent in the sense of adept at communicating high impact information effectively). What will these blind men do, once they have some idea (or so they think) of what this elephant is, and what it might do?



We live in a hyperlinked reality, but we couldn't read or write that way in 1976. Now we can: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/The_Poems_of_John_Godfrey_Saxe/The_Blind_Men_and_the_Elephant https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Blind_men_and_an_elephant - The above engraving was published in 1907. Saxe's popular poem, first published in 1872, could well have been taught in NC's inaugural English Lit classes of 1908. At Harvard, Ralph Waldo Emerson and his student Henry Thoreau loved Sanskrit.

In the recorded texts, the Buddha does not cite the parable as coming from an earlier source, but rather tells it as a story about a king from the past. [Access to Insight +2](#)

The earliest known written record of this parable is found in the **Tittha Sutta** (part of the *Udāna* in the Pali Canon), which dates back to roughly 500 BCE during the lifetime of the Buddha. [Wikipedia](#)

How the Buddha Frames the Story

In the *Tittha Sutta*, the Buddha uses the parable to address his monks about rival religious teachers who were constantly arguing over spiritual truths. [Buddhism now +1](#)

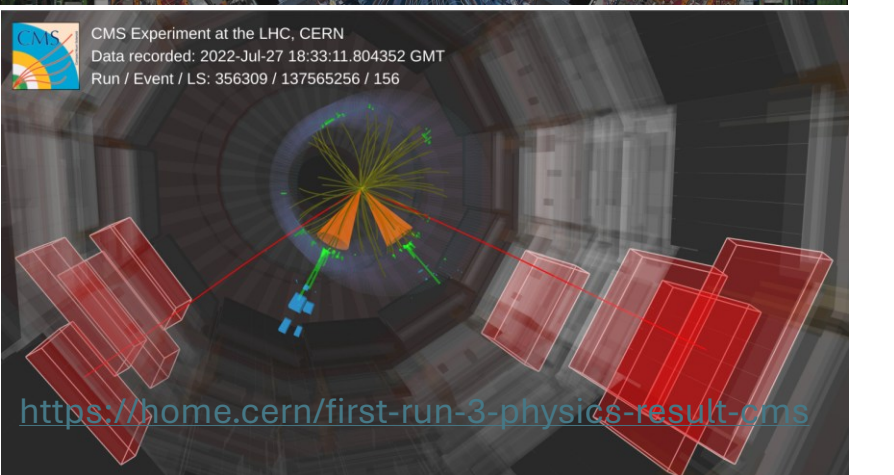
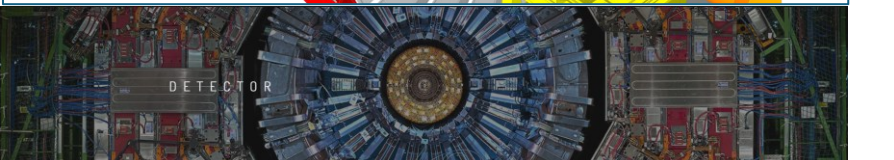
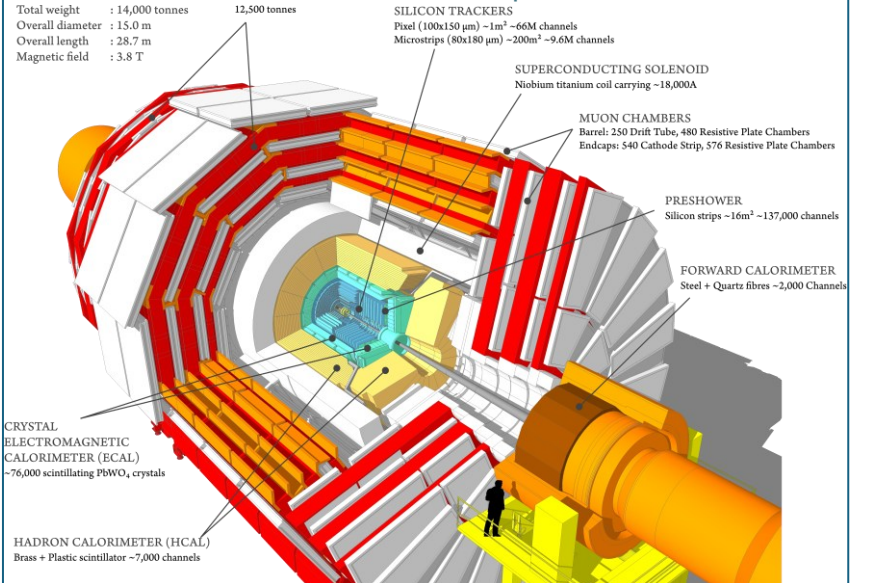
- **The Framing:** The Buddha begins by saying, "*Once in the past, bhikkhus, there was a certain king in this same Savatthi...*".
- **The Narrative:** He describes how this ancient king gathered blind men to examine an elephant just for his own amusement to watch them argue.
- **The Conclusion:** After telling the story, the Buddha delivers his own "inspired utterance" (verse), comparing the blind men to sectarian teachers who only see one side of the truth and argue out of attachment to their own views. [Buddhism now +2](#)

Historical Context & Debate

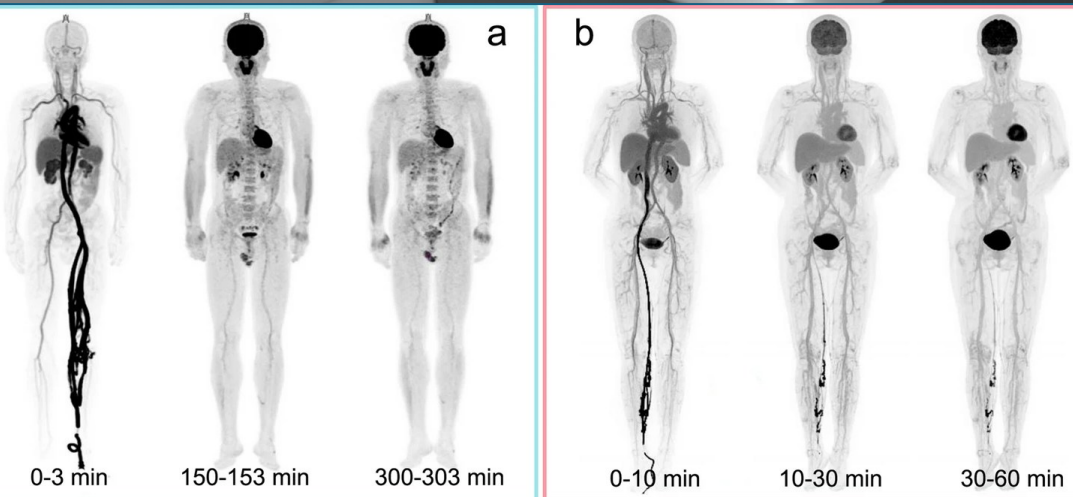
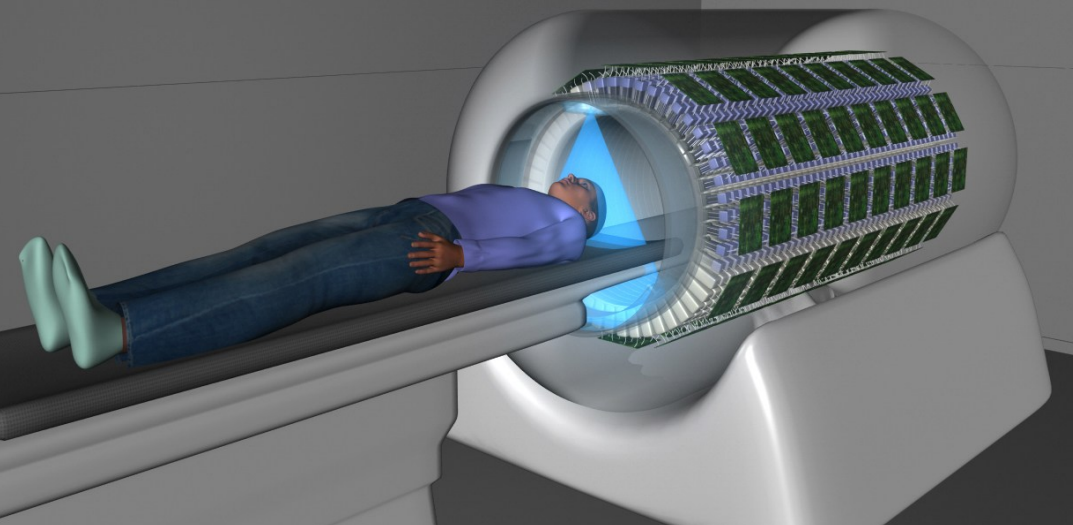
While the *written* record belongs to Buddhism, scholars of Indian philosophy point out a few nuances: [Wikipedia +1](#)

- **Oral Tradition:** It is highly likely the story existed as a popular regional folklore or proverb in ancient India before the Buddha adopted it. Proverbs during this era were often shared across cultures before being written down.
- **Jain Claims:** Some scholars suggest the core idea aligns so perfectly with the Jain philosophical concept of *Anekantavada* (the many-sidedness of reality) that it may have originated in the ancient Jain oral tradition around or before the 5th century BCE. [Facebook · Mini Philosophy +3](#)

Learning: Many things can be described many ways, with useful descriptions complementary to one another.



A candidate event in which a top quark pair is produced. Each top quark decays to a b quark and a W boson. Each b quark produces a jet, shown by the orange cones and each W boson decays to a neutrino (not seen) and a muon (shown by the red lines). Source: [CERN \(CDS\)](https://home.cern/first-run-3-physics-result-cms)



Performance and application of the total-body PET/CT scanner: a literature review



My NC Institutional Lifetime Achievement Award

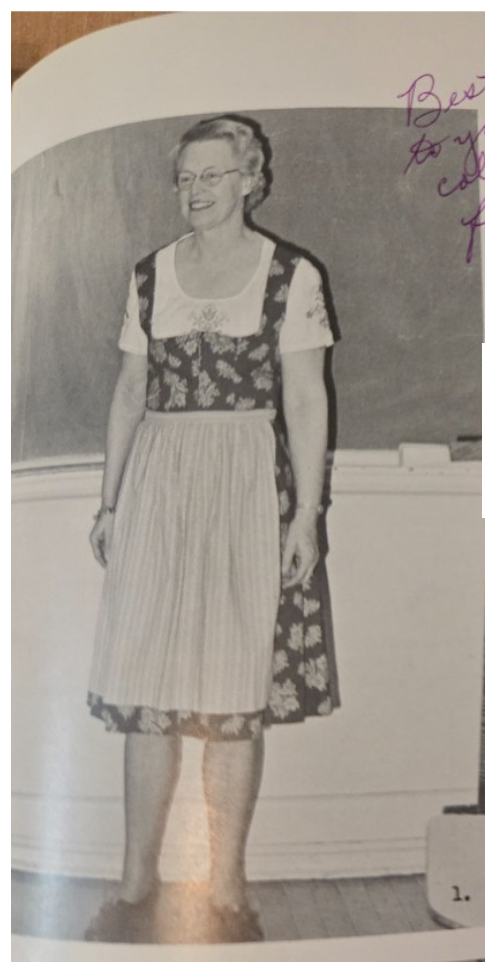
This goes to the Captain of our ship, Mr. Rodkey, here shown astride his majestic steed and approving the inaugural Rowdy Squad Regalia, and to his staff. In September, 1976 I was flying to Boston with a layover in Chicago when I discovered they had pinball machines there (that's me on the wall over there, with plenty of hair but no beard). Being skilled in the art and never tilting, I won a few bonus rounds, and missed my connecting flight. Mr. Rodkey, who had a brother in the Boston Area, had arranged for his brother to meet me at Boston Logan Airport and get me to Harvard Yard. When I did not arrive, he somehow tracked me down and got me there after dark to drop me off 1000 miles from anybody I knew. I think it was students like me who drove Mr. Rodkey to his tricycle, but he was ever up to the job.

Life lesson learned: Focus! And Priorities!
Technical lesson learned: If you absolutely must multi-task, keep a sharp eye on the clock.



Subjects to be Addressed by this Talk:

- Reflection on and Celebration of our Teachers and our Community of 50 years ago, with Life Lessons Learned
- Sharing personal experiences and anecdotes, from Applied Mathematics and Physics applied to High-Energy Particles and to Medical Imaging, with insights I have gained from observing and appreciating many wonderful friends and communities over 50 years.
- A Harvard's-Eye view – meaning my somewhat unusual, definitely particular, and very biased perspective - of what's happened over the past 50 years in Science, Technology, Education, and Society, and hopes for the future.
- Pure and Applied Science as Public Goods and Collective Effort, within a (Partially) Free Democratic Culture under the Rule of Law – a Utopia. Elite at what, again?

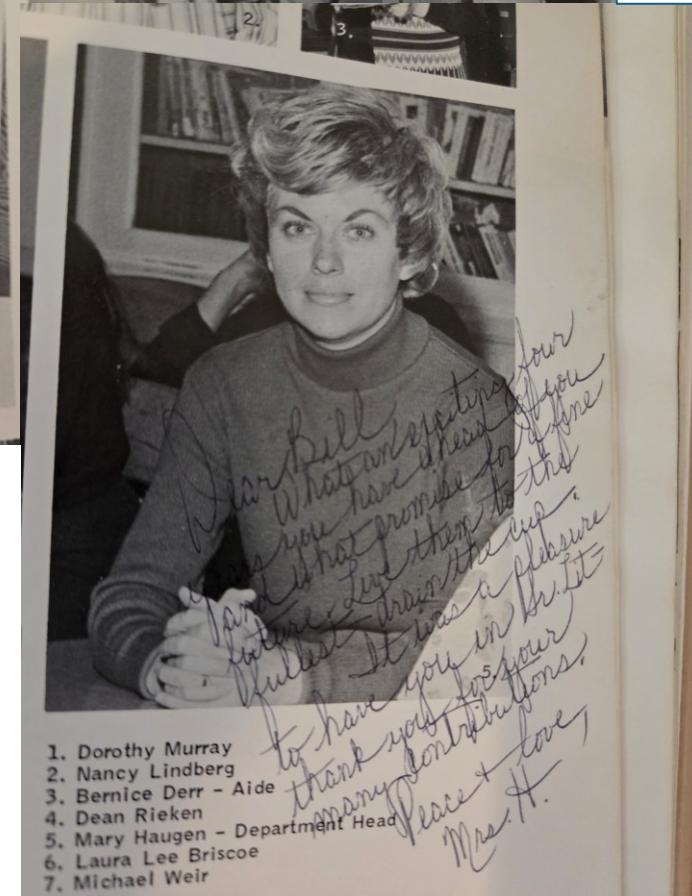


Best of success to you Bill - at college and in the future. Will your sesquipedalianism come in handy sometime I hope? Laura Lee Briscoe

Best of success to you Bill – at college and in the future. Will your sesquipedalianism come in handy sometime I hope? Laura Lee Briscoe

Sesquipedalianism is a noun defined as the **practice of using long, multi-syllabic, or obscure words** in speech or writing. The Roman poet Horace famously used the phrase *sesquipedalia verba* ("words a foot-and-a-half long") in his work *Ars Poetica* to mock writers who used overly large, pompous language.

*Dear Bill,
What an exciting four years you have ahead and what promise for a fine future. Live them to the fullest – drain the cup. It was a pleasure to have you in Senior Lit.- thank you for your many contributions.
Peace + love, Mrs. H.*



1. Dorothy Murray
2. Nancy Lindberg
3. Bernice Derr - Aide
4. Dean Rieken
5. Mary Haugen - Department Head
6. Laura Lee Briscoe
7. Michael Weir